HARDBOARD DISC

This is a method I use most of the time. I have several discs of different sizes going up in 25mm stages. All you need to make these is some hardboard or even thick card. The first stage is to draw a circle with a pair of compasses, then cut the circle out very carefully on the line you have drawn, and then push a bradawl through the centre where the compass point was.

To use these discs, pick a size that fits the blank size, or one that is just smaller, and line the disc up on the blank so you have an equal space all around the edge. Now use a bradawl though the hole in the centre and press into the blanks to mark the centre. This can be used on the end of branch timber to find the centre. You can use this on planks as well to mark out bowl blanks. Unless you want all the blanks to be the same size you can lay different size discs on to get the most out of the plank. This system works very well on natural edge bowl blanks; this is the method I use mostly on this type of timber.

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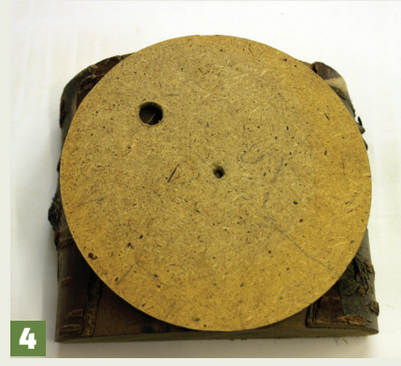
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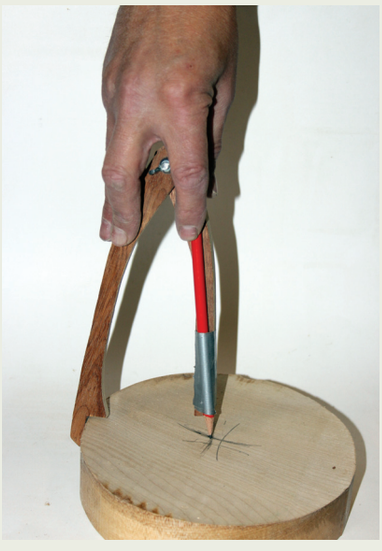


ODD LEGS/CALLIPERS

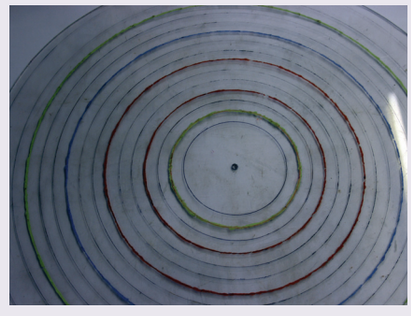
These are a compass type of equipment; the difference is one leg has a step which you can place on the edge of the blank, then roughly set the other leg to the centre of the blank. As you can see this is a homemade pair made from two pieces of timber joined with a bolt and wing nut, with a pencil taped to the straight leg.

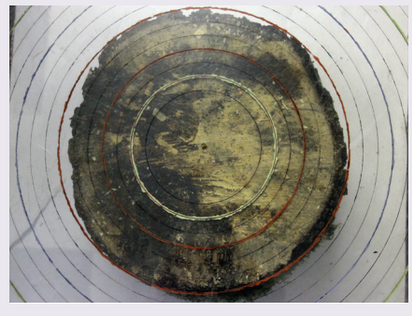
To use these, place the step on the edge and open out so the pencil is around halfway across the blank, lock this setting. Now draw an arc then move round the edge of the blank drawing arcs until you can see where the centre of the blank is, then mark this. These are mainly for round blanks.

PLASTIC DISC TO FIND CENTRE

This is used to find centres on larger irregular shaped pieces of timber. Simply, this is a large piece of plastic sheet – acetate in this case – with circles drawn on it. You could use polycarbonate sheet too: this is strong and withstands a lot of abuse without breaking. I used a pair of dividers to score circles on the disc: the reason I wanted to score is so I can mark the circles with a marker pen, and using different colours makes lining this up easier. You can set the rings at fixed sizes sat every centimetre or inch, but have enough marked rings to make life easy for yourself. Then drill a small hole in the centre of the disc so you can use a bradawl to mark the timber surface.

Place the disc on the timber and adjust until you have found the centre of the timber or as near as possible and mark. This will help you visualise where you may wish to hold very irregular pieces like burrs, logs and so on. Don't be fooled though as it can be used for working on other pieces too.





Conclusion

Finding the centres of work helps by enabling you to minimisise vibration and also wastage of timber. That said, a log or burr can be so irregular in shape that finding the true centre is very difficult, but getting close is important. No one wants to work on material that is heavily off-centre or out of balance, unless it is something we have to do. We really don't want to have the lathe vibrating all over the place for longer than necessary.

Given that we work with timber from a variety of sources and in various shapes, even if we buy pre-prepared blanks, they are rarely truly round when we buy them. There is no one perfect way to find the centre of something and there are certainly more methods available than those shown here. However, these are cheap and easy to use ways that form the backbone of the majority of methods used. Absolute accurancy is rarely required, so 'close enough' is often good sufficient for the majority of work. ●

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